

Florida Gators - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-20 underlying quality; dangerous but volatile
Preseason consensus	AP unranked (51 points) · SEC media 9th · SP+ No. 20
Returning production	66% overall (No. 11) · Off. 55% (No. 65) · Def. 77% (No. 1)
Primer power rating	+15.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.0 wins · most likely 7-5
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ Better - new staff, healthy skill talent and defensive continuity raise the ceiling
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: OC Buster Faulkner's pro-style hybrid should feature RB Jadan Baugh and a deep WR group, with QB Aaron Philo now atop the depth chart and QB Tramell Jones Jr. continuing to push him. DC Brad White builds around ILB Myles Graham and JACK Jayden Woods; the rebuilt OL remains the larger structural uncertainty.

Bottom line: Florida has top-20 underlying quality and real upside, but limited starting proof at QB, OL uncertainty and a top-10 schedule keep the Gators dangerous rather than dependable.

Beats expectations if: QB Aaron Philo gives Florida efficient play, the OL settles quickly and the defense absorbs major departures without losing disruption.

Disappoints if: Passing-down offense stays inefficient and front/secondary turnover erodes the defense's strong continuity signal.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB decision:** QB Aaron Philo has been named QB1 and will receive the bulk of first-team work; QB Tramell Jones Jr. remains the primary challenger and backup.
- 2 ★ RB Jadan Baugh:** 1,170 rush yds in 2025; SEC second-team recognition plus Doak Walker, Maxwell and Paul Hornung watchlists.
- 3 ♦ New staff:** HC Jon Sumrall, OC Buster Faulkner and DC Brad White are external hires; OC Buster Faulkner is the offensive play-caller.
- 4 Defensive continuity with turnover:** 77% returning production (No. 1), but several major NFL/transfer departures must be replaced.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** SP+ SOS is **No. 9**, with at Texas → Georgia → Oklahoma → at Kentucky late in the year.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	4-8 (2-6 SEC)	● Poor
Scoring	21.6 PPG	● Poor
Total offense	341.3 YPG	● Below average
Rush offense	136.8 YPG · 4.3 YPC	● Below average
Pass efficiency	6.56 YPA · 18 TD / 14 INT	● Below average
Third downs	34.2%	● Poor
Scoring defense	24.0 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	376.8 YPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Rush defense	153.9 YPG · 4.0 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass defense	222.9 YPG · 7.99 YPA · 13 TD allowed	● Below average

Florida's offense was the clear 2025 weakness, especially scoring and third downs. The defense was closer to average overall, though pass efficiency remained a problem.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	−2.27 · No. 83	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	−0.004 · No. 67	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	43.8% · No. 53	● Average / mixed
Off. explosive-play rate	11.7% · No. 79	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	15.2% · No. 66	● Average / mixed
Opp.-adjusted defense	+0.46 · No. 62	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	−0.033 · No. 51	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	43.8% · No. 99	● Below average
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	11.3% · No. 50	● Good / above average
Havoc created	14.3% · No. 93	● Below average

Advanced-stat read: Play-level offense was closer to average than the traditional totals suggest. The defense limited explosives well but allowed too much routine success and created too little havoc.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	◆ Jon Sumrall - from Tulane HC	● ↑ Strong reset; new-system transition adds uncertainty
OC / play-caller	◆ Buster Faulkner - from Georgia Tech OC	● ↑ Play-calling background targets the 2025 offensive weakness
DC	◆ Brad White - from Kentucky DC	● ↔ Proven SEC coordinator; defensive transition still matters

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Aaron Philo	Georgia Tech	● ↔ Named QB1 after winning the preseason competition; starting proof remains limited.
◆ WR Eric Singleton Jr.	Auburn	● ↑ Veteran speed and prior OC Buster Faulkner system experience
◆ OL Harrison Moore	Georgia Tech	● ↔ Starting experience; center competition remains open
◆ OL TJ Shanahan Jr.	Penn State	● ↔ Experienced interior option for a rebuilt line

Out	To	Loss
QB DJ Lagway	Baylor	● ↔ Starting experience leaves; replacement level is uncertain
C Jake Slaughter	NFL (L.A. Chargers), Round 2, No. 63	● ↓ Major center and continuity loss
OT Austin Barber	NFL (Cleveland), Round 3, No. 86	● ↓ Proven tackle departure
OL Damieon George Jr.	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ Twelve-game starting RG leaves
WR Eugene Wilson III	LSU	● ↔ Meaningful receiver departure; replacements soften the loss

Offensive net: Skill talent and the new structure create a ● ↑ **modest upgrade**, but QB and OL transitions keep the gain uncertain.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ S DJ Coleman	Baylor	● ↑ Experienced safety option
◆ STAR Kanye Clark	UCLA	● ↔ Defined STAR role; secondary rotation remains unsettled
◆ DL Emmanuel Oyejede	Jacksonville State	● ↔ Useful front rotation with SEC projection risk

Out	To	Loss
DT Caleb Banks	NFL (Minnesota), Round 1, No. 18	● ↓ High-value interior loss
CB Devin Moore	NFL (Dallas), Round 4, No. 114	● ↓ Proven secondary loss
EDGE Tyreack Sapp	NFL (Cleveland), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Twelve-game starter departs
DB Jordan Castell	Kentucky	● ↓ Material secondary experience departs

Defensive net: A strong returning core keeps the ceiling high, but major front and secondary losses make the projection ● ↔ **similar with a wide range**.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Pro-style hybrid; matchup/space creation; run plus perimeter/downfield passing	RB Jadan Baugh and a deep WR group	Obvious passing downs if QB/OL roles do not settle
Defense	Flexible fronts blending 3-4 and 4-3 principles	Returning anchors and good explosive-play prevention	Replacing departures while improving success-rate defense and havoc
Special teams	Transfer-led specialist competition	K Patrick Durkin and P Alec Clark bring strong preseason recognition	Both primary jobs remain unsettled

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	Aaron Philo is QB1; little starting proof keeps the projection volatile.
RB	● A–	● ↔	High	RB Jadan Baugh is a proven 1,170-yard centerpiece
WR	● B+	● ↑	Medium-high	WR Vernell Brown III, WR Dallas Wilson and WR Eric Singleton Jr. give real depth
TE	● C+	● ↔	Low	Rotation options; little proven high-end receiving impact
OL	● B–	● ↔	Low	Three major starters gone; center/best-five still unsettled
DL/Edge	● B+	● ↔	Medium-low	JACK Jayden Woods and DL LJ McCray provide upside after major losses
LB	● B+	● ↔	Medium	ILB Myles Graham anchors a less-proven supporting group
Secondary	● B–	● ↔	Medium-low	Several useful options, but major departures and role battles remain
Special teams	● B	● ↔	Medium-low	K Patrick Durkin/P Alec Clark have upside; jobs are not locked
Coaching	● B+	● ↑	Medium-low	Strong new trio, with transition risk
Overall	● B+	● ↑	Medium-low	Top-20 profile constrained by QB/OL and roster turnover

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 22, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
★ Jadan Baugh	RB	● National star	SEC Coaches 2nd RB · SEC Media 2nd RB / 3rd AP · Doak Walker, Maxwell, Paul Hornung	Proven 1,170-yard centerpiece
Vernell Brown III	WR	● High-end conference starter	SEC Coaches 3rd · SEC Media 3rd · Paul Hornung	Major receiving and return role
Dallas Wilson	WR	● High-upside conference starter	-	Healthy again and raises the WR ceiling
◆ Aaron Philo (TR: Georgia Tech)	QB	● Unproven starter / system fit	-	Named QB1 after his familiarity with Buster Faulkner's system helped separate him in camp.
Myles Graham	ILB	● High-end conference starter	Bednarik · Butkus	Led Florida with 76 tackles in 2025
Jayden Woods	JACK	● High-end starter / breakout candidate	SEC Coaches 3rd · SEC Media 3rd	Major returning edge role
LJ McCray	DL	● High-upside athlete / health return	-	Back in camp after a season-ending 2025 injury
◆ Harrison Moore (TR: Georgia Tech)	C	● Solid Power 4 starter projection	Rimington	Starting experience in an open center race

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Difficult; little margin for QB/OL growing pains
Difficulty	● 9/10 · Very hard · SP+ SOS No. 9
Hardest stretch	at Texas → Georgia → Oklahoma → at Kentucky; bye before Georgia
Swing games	at Auburn, at Missouri, South Carolina, Oklahoma, at Florida State
Advantage	Two home tune-ups before SEC play; bye separates Texas and Georgia
Expected	7.0 wins · likely 7-5
Floor / ceiling	5-7 / 9-3

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	The 4-8 record can hide a top-20 SP+ profile; new-coach optimism can push the other way
Back them when	Getting points or laying a modest number when the run/WR matchup can protect the passing game
Fade/pass when	Laying a premium against a strong front before QB/OL efficiency is proven
Key monitor	Aaron Philo's early efficiency and Tramell Jones Jr. role, OL combination, WR Dallas Wilson workload, DL LJ McCray availability, defensive havoc
Week 1 baseline	vs. Florida Atlantic: rating-only fair baseline Florida -23.0 using FAU SP+ as a non-project proxy; compare with the live market before betting Live market: Florida -26.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Florida has a credible path to a major rebound. OC Buster Faulkner gets RB Jadan Baugh and a deep WR room, while DC Brad White inherits a strong defensive continuity signal led by ILB Myles Graham and JACK Jayden Woods.

QB, OL and defensive turnover keep the projection volatile, and SP+ SOS No. 9 leaves little room for a slow start. The sound preseason position is **improved and dangerous, but not yet dependable at a premium price**; 7-5 remains the baseline.

About this primer

DRWhittier · cfb.drwhittier.com · X: [@GatorBait7](https://twitter.com/GatorBait7) · Version 1.0 - August 25, 2026

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [QB camp](#) · [OL camp](#) · [WR Wilson](#) · [DL McCray](#) · [OC Faulkner](#) · [DC White](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [schedule](#) · [2025 stats](#) · [CFB Graphs](#) · [cfbfastR](#) · [QB1 update](#)

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